

SOC Investigation Report - Microsoft Defender Real-time Protection Disabled

No confirmed malicious Indicators of Compromise (IOCs) were identified during this investigation.

Client	Kerning City Dental (KCD)
Prepared by	Graham McKean
Date	August 2026
Classification	CONFIDENTIAL
Severity	Medium

Findings

Alert	KCD - Endpoint - Windows Defender Disabled
Classification	Suspicious - User-associated Microsoft Defender configuration changes; no confirmed compromise
Severity	Medium
Detection Source	Splunk SIEM
Affected Host	DESKTOP-Q1HN49.kerningcitydental.ca
Associated User Session	DESKTOP-Q1HN49\KCD-Contractor
Windows Defender Event	Event ID 5001
Security Utility	Defender Control (dControl) v2.1
dControl Path	C:\PerfLogs\LB3B\dControl.exe
dControl SHA256	1EF6C1A4DFDC39B63BFE650CA81AB89510DE6C0D3D7C608AC5BE80033E559326
MITRE ATT&CK	T1562.001 - Impair Defenses: Disable or Modify Tools

Investigation Summary

The investigation confirmed that Microsoft Defender Real-time Protection was disabled on DESKTOP-Q1HN49.kerningcitydental.ca on 30 July 2026 at 18:40:59 UTC. KCD-Contractor was active immediately beforehand. SecHealthUI.exe and SecurityHealthHost.exe were observed in the KCD-Contractor context, with SecurityHealthHost.exe activity less than one second before the protection-state change. This is consistent with an interactive change through Windows Security, but the telemetry does not record the user selecting the control, so direct attribution is not conclusive.

At 18:40:59 UTC, services.exe running as NT AUTHORITY\SYSTEM modified the Defender-related WdNisDrv service configuration immediately before Event ID 5001. Additional changes affected SpyNet/MAPS reporting, Tamper Protection and sample submission. At 18:42:43 UTC, KCD-Contractor deliberately launched dControl.exe from C:\PerfLogs\LB3B\; the utility subsequently operated with SYSTEM-level privileges and used the /TI option. Because dControl executed about two minutes after the original disable event, it is not attributed as the confirmed cause of Event ID 5001. Historical telemetry also showed the same account executing the same binary on 13 July 2026.

OSINT matched the SHA256 to Sordum Defender Control v2.1 and Microsoft classifies Defender Control as HackTool:Win32/DefenderControl. This supports identification of the utility, but its dual-use nature and the absence of authorisation records mean malicious intent is not established. No evidence reviewed confirmed malware execution or broader endpoint compromise.

Timeline

Time (UTC)	Event
30 Jul 2026 18:40:51	SecHealthUI.exe observed in KCD-Contractor user context.
18:40:58	SecurityHealthHost.exe activity observed under KCD-Contractor.
18:40:59	services.exe modified Defender-related WdNisDrv configuration.
18:40:59	Defender Event ID 5001 recorded Real-time Protection disabled.
18:41:03-18:41:07	Additional Defender configuration changes affected SpyNet/MAPS, Tamper Protection and sample submission.
18:42:33	C:\PerfLogs\LB3B\ and dControl.exe created during the observed session.
18:42:43	KCD-Contractor launched dControl.exe interactively through Windows Explorer.
18:42:44	dControl executed as NT AUTHORITY\SYSTEM, including use of /TI.

Investigation

Validated the Splunk detection, recovered the original Defender event, reviewed Defender Operational events and correlated Sysmon telemetry around the protection-state change. Investigated the active KCD-Contractor session and Windows Security processes, analysed dControl execution, reviewed historical use of the same binary, and performed OSINT validation of Defender Control v2.1.

5Ws and 1H

Who	The activity occurred during an active DESKTOP-Q1HN49\KCD-Contractor session. The telemetry does not directly record the user selecting the Real-time Protection control.
What	Defender Real-time Protection was disabled, followed by related Defender configuration changes. dControl v2.1 was subsequently deliberately executed by KCD-Contractor.
When	Real-time Protection disabled at 18:40:59 UTC on 30 Jul 2026; dControl launched at approximately 18:42:43 UTC.
Where	DESKTOP-Q1HN49.kerningcitydental.ca.
Why	The precise reason for disabling Defender could not be established. dControl demonstrates deliberate use of a security-control modification utility, but organisational authorisation is unknown.
How	The initial state change occurred during an active user session immediately after Windows Security interface activity, with Defender-related service/configuration changes recorded. dControl was later launched manually and obtained SYSTEM-level execution.

Observed Indicators

Host	DESKTOP-Q1HN49.kerningcitydental.ca
User	DESKTOP-Q1HN49\KCD-Contractor
Application	dControl.exe v2.1
Path	C:\PerfLogs\LB3B\dControl.exe
SHA256	1EF6C1A4DFDC39B63BFE650CA81AB89510DE6C0D3D7C608AC5BE80033E559326
Event IDs	5001, 5007

Confirmed Malicious IOCs

None identified.

External Threat Intelligence / OSINT

The SHA256 matches the published Sordum Defender Control v2.1 executable. Sordum documents that Defender Control may use TrustedInstaller privileges when required to modify Defender protections,

consistent with the observed SYSTEM-level and /TI activity. Microsoft Security Intelligence classifies Defender Control as HackTool:Win32/DefenderControl. This supports identification of the binary but does not, by itself, establish malicious intent because the utility is dual-use.

Assessment

Classification: Suspicious - User-associated Microsoft Defender configuration changes; no confirmed compromise. The initial disablement occurred during an active KCD-Contractor session and immediately after Windows Security activity, but the exact initiating action remains unresolved. dControl was deliberately and repeatedly executed by KCD-Contractor, but it ran after the initial disable event and is therefore not identified as its confirmed cause. Organisational authorisation remains an operational question.

Recommendations

- Immediately verify the current Microsoft Defender protection state and re-enable Real-time Protection, Tamper Protection and other affected settings if they are not at the approved security baseline.
- If the protection changes or Defender Control use were unauthorised, isolate or restrict the endpoint while the activity is investigated and preserve relevant evidence.
- Confirm with the client/system owner whether KCD-Contractor was authorised to disable Defender and whether Defender Control is an approved administrative utility.
- Hunt the dControl SHA256 and path across the environment to determine whether the same binary exists or has executed on additional endpoints.
- Restrict unauthorised use of tools capable of disabling or modifying endpoint security controls; consider application-control or endpoint policies.
- Retain the hash, execution evidence and relevant Defender/Sysmon telemetry for future detection and correlation.

Investigation Limitations

The available telemetry does not directly record the user selecting or changing the Real-time Protection setting, so the exact initiating action cannot be conclusively attributed. dControl executed after the initial disablement and cannot be established as the cause of Event ID 5001. The supplied evidence does not establish the file signer, file size, original creation/download source, or environment-wide prevalence of the hash; these remain validation items if suitable telemetry or endpoint access becomes available. Technical telemetry also cannot determine whether the activity was organisationally authorised. No conclusion of malware infection, threat-actor involvement or broader endpoint compromise has been made.